By the time the Mauryan empire was established, the second cycle of India's urbanization had been underway for a millennium. Taxila in the north-west was not just a vibrant city but an important intellectual hub. In the east, Tamralipti was established as a major port; it is likely that Emperor Ashoka sent his son Mahindra on a mission to Sri Lanka from there. The site is located across the river from Kolkata and is not far from the port of Haldia. The name 'Tamralipta' means 'full of copper' and may have originally been linked to export of copper goods. Archaeological excavations have revealed punch-marked coins from this period. As we will see in the next chapter, the port would evolve into an important international trading hub in subsequent centuries.

The imperial capital of Pataliputra, of course, was the most important city in the empire. Megasthenes, [27] the Macedonian ambassador to Chandragupta, tells us that Pataliputra was surrounded by massive wooden palisades with 64 gates and 570 watch-towers. The city was shaped like a parallelogram 14.5 km in length and 2.5 km in breadth. Even if one does not take the numbers literally, they imply a very large city. Tower-bases and stockades found from excavations corroborate this. The main gates had wide timber-floored walkways with bridges across a moat system. The moat system, fed by the Son river, was almost 200 metres wide on the landward side. Along the Ganga, wooden piles were sunk into the mud to protect against inundation. Brick and stone were used to construct buildings inside the walls, especially for important structures. However, wood was a common building material and fires were a major hazard. [28] Megasthenes tells us that he had seen all the great cities of the east, including Susa and Ecbatana, but that Pataliputra was the greatest city in the world. Unfortunately, further excavations have become increasingly difficult as the growth of modern Patna has now covered the site.

What was it like to live in a Mauryan city? Kautilya's *Arthashastra* has a long list of municipal laws that give us a good insight into the civic concerns of the times. [29] For instance, there were traffic rules stating that